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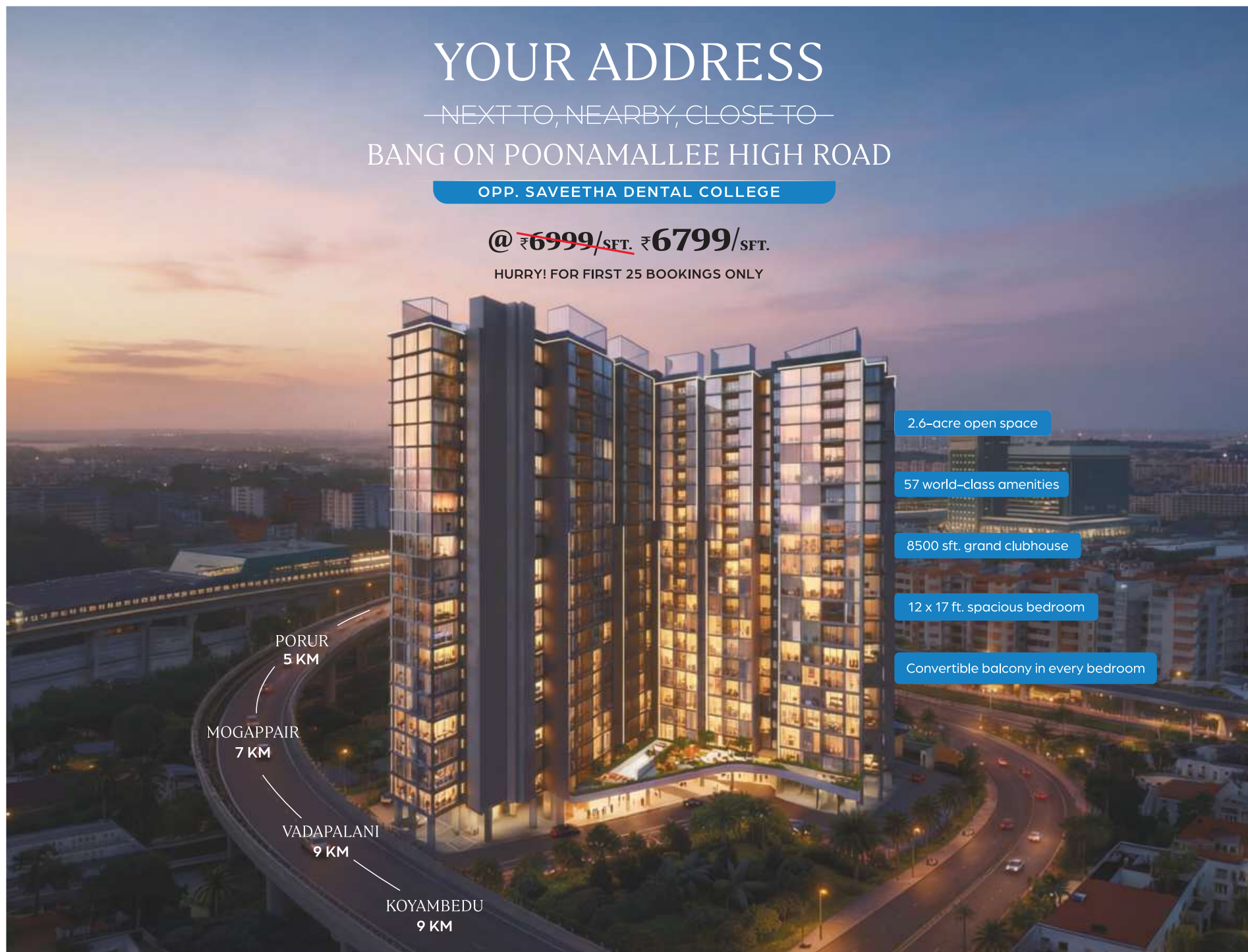
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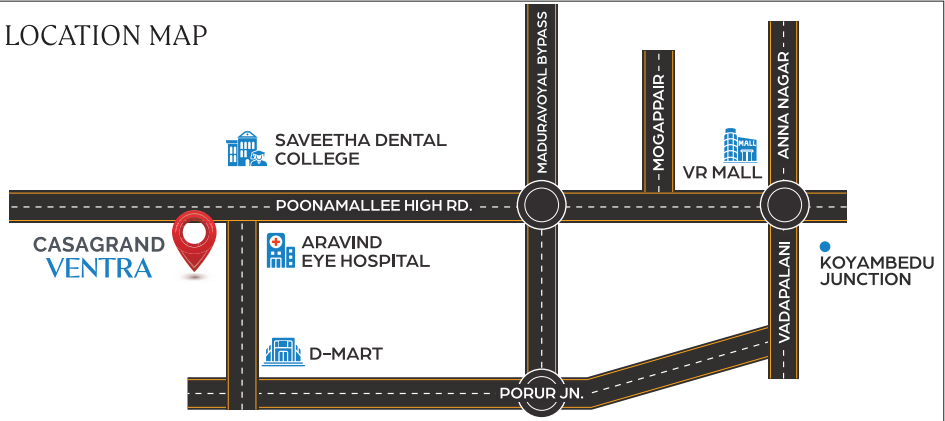
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FEED' THE WHALE, RECEIVE A BAG

A Chennai-based startup is populating the sands of Marina with "whales" and "fish" that function as reverse vending machines **P2**



A 'DEVELOPING' STORY WITH CIVIC AND SOCIAL UNDERPINNINGS

A civic engagement of a kind that involves multiple stakeholders, Project Thiruvannamiyur Mada Street is refreshing its initiative to reclaim a space from unauthorised parking and squalor **P4**

What Mandaveli voters want

PRINCE FREDERICK

There is a new generation of fuel guzzlers, and it is found in Mandaveli, and even Mylapore. These motorcycles 'swig down' petrol when they are parked in the driveway.

Mandaveli Raja Street residents welfare association has put down petrol theft among the issues plaguing residents of Mandaveli. Ganga Sridhar, a key member of the association, notes that petrol theft has been noticed for at least two years, but has spiked in recent times, probably because of the fuel scarcity scare witnessed a while ago on account of the geopolitical situation in West Asia with ramifications reaching distant shores, including our own.

Along with mobile thefts, siphoning of petrol from two-wheelers is on the rise, says Ganga, adding that residents regularly confirm its prevalence on the Namma Mylai WhatsApp group. Based on CCTV footage, youngsters are into this crime. "A plastic bottle is connected via pipe to siphon petrol. The perpetrators leave the bottle attached, move to other bikes, and

return after 30 minutes to collect fuel," says Ganga, her report shaped by what has been seen in CCTV footage. There is patrolling by police, but it has to be targeted with police personnel having their eyes peeled for this petty theft. In general, petty thefts are on the rise, according to her. Ganga notes that preventive measures should not centre around just improved lighting, but go beyond it.

And Ganga believes there is a correlation between petty thefts and another issue in Mandaveli, easy availability of liquor.

Liquor availability

The Tasmac outlet near Mandaveli on Venkatakrishna Road has been a source of great angst for Mandaveli residents, and it is not surprising Ganga brings it up. She notes the issue has been escalated up to the Supreme Court.

"Due to this outlet, the area within a radius of 500 metres becomes unhygienic, on account of open urination; drunk individuals lie around in an inebriated state even during daytime; the stretch is unsafe for women and children," observes Ganga.

RAPRA starts a children's club

Raja Annamalaipuram Residents Association (RAPRA), in a new initiative to impart life skills to children of age group 5-15 years has started a club called RAPRA Kids Club (RKC) at no 13, Second Main Road in R.A.Puram. This club organised by a group of women with different background and experience will train these children in betterment of knowledge, inculcate civic sense, develop through fun games, building in them confidence and courage to face things, says a press release.

The club will be meeting every fortnight

and if required more frequently to ease the tedium of pursuing school curriculum for the children. The club will have its first activity on April 25. This is not just a summer camp but would go on regularly, said a release.

The membership for joining this club is absolutely free and RAPRA's objective is to mould the citizens of tomorrow with better perspective and outlook, the release adds.

Parents who desire to enroll their children in this club may contact Bhuvana Pasupathy at 9176544899

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'Feed' the whale, receive a bag

LIFFY THOMAS

A whale 12 feet tall if it stood on its fluke, sits squat on the sands of the Marina Beach. It is a shape-shifter of a whale, combining the contours of a bin and a cloth bag. It is both of these things rolled into one: drop a PET bottle in the bin and get a cloth bag as reward. When one drops a PET bottle in this reverse vending machine, they might appear to be feeding a whale because of the machine's design.

Needless to say it is not a whale.

"InstaBin", as this contraption is called, started operating since April 6, near the Marina swimming pool. Two more reverse vending machines, both designed to resemble a whales, are expected to hit the sands of the Marina next week. In addition, six fish-shaped reverse vending machines have been placed at strategic points between the Light House and Anna Memorial section of the beach.

Chennai-based startup InstaGood's design to reward those showing civic sense at public places is drawing considerable attention both online and on the ground.

The firm came up with the idea after seeing a similar machine being placed at Elliot's Beach in Besant Nagar fail on account of people dropping stones instead of PET bottles.

"Our 'Meendum Man-

japai" (automated machine to dispense cloth bags) machines were already at 60 locations and that is when we thought we should design an Indian version of reverse vending machine where people do not have to pay anything and concerns such as people dropping hard objects should be countered," says Krishna Priyadarshini Elanchezhian, CEO, InstaGood.

Their first machine was placed at Lulu Mall in Bengaluru, where the management wanted to give loyalty coupons to those drop-

Insta solutions

Krishna Priyadarshini Elanchezhian and Vijayaragavan Visuvamithiran, two classmates from College of Engineering Guindy are the founders of InstaGood. The startup manufactures and designs smart vending machines. InstaCoCo, an automatic coconut water vending machine, was their first product.

"The product did face considerable challenge and after a lull we came up with a mask vending machine during the pandemic, which did very well," says Vijayaragavan, a junior research fellow from the biophotonics lab at IIT-Madras who oversees the tech aspects.

They started the enterprise with a seed fund of ₹ 5 lakh

and today are happy with the response they been getting for it various vending machines (InstaPad, InstaBin and InstaBag).

"All our tech-driven solutions reduce waste and is sustainable," says Vijayaragavan.

ping PET bottles. This was followed by another machine placed at Commercial Street in Bangalore with Ranstad India as sponsor.

The patented design slowly started getting corporates' attention. As part of its CSR outreach, Swiss banking software firm Temenos sponsored five machines in Chennai, which can be spotted at Thiruvottiyur Thangal bus stop, Marina beach, Broadway bus stand, Koyambedu flower market and Besant Nagar beach.

Later, they bagged the tender from Greater Chennai Corporation for placing nine machines at Marina, work on which is still on. The company manufactures and maintains the machine and sees this as a viable model to reduce single use plastics in cities.

The design

By virtue of live cameras installed

in them, these IoT-enabled machines collect real time data. There is no need for manpower except when the dropped PET bottles have to be collected and transported. "This ideally requires a roof but we have not come across any issues in the last three months, so they are kept in the open," she says.

The team has been tweaking the design based on inputs from the ground. For instance, the one placed at Marina beach was incorporated with sound to speak to the public dropping the bottle but that feature got lost amidst the sound of waves.

The machine accepts anything but only dispenses a cloth bag for the PET bottle dropped.

To ensure people do not walk away with multiple cloth bags to litter them on the sands, the team has tweaked the programme so that the waiting time is made lon-

A Chennai-based startup is populating the sands of Marina with "whales" and "fish" that function as reverse vending machines, dispensing a cloth bag for every PET bottle dropped in them

One of the three whale-shaped reverse vending machines at the Marina Beach; and (below) the fish-shaped one; and co-founders Krishna Priyadarshini and Vijayaragavan. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



PLAN YOUR WEEK

Creative camp in Mylapore

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Chennai Kendra is starting "Creative Summer Camp 2026" in performing arts, yoga, arts and crafts, sloka chanting, games and puzzles and cultural tours from April 20.

The short-term courses cater to all age groups, with expert instructors guiding each course to ensure personalised attention and a wholesome experience, said a release. Courses offered include computer classes, AI in everyday life, keyboard, drawing and painting, free style dance, yoga, and vocal music.

The camp is on from April 20 to May 31; 10 a.m. to 1 p.m.

Short term courses are on from May 1st to May 31 Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan is at East Mada Street, Mylapore.

Contact: 98843 66700/ 98843 64700/ 98843 35700

Session for Class XII students

Studio41 in Besant Nagar is conducting a training workshop for students of Class XII aspiring to pursue careers in art. Artist Kamala Ravikumar, who runs the studio, will help students prepare for examinations like National Institute of Design, National Institute of Fashion Technology, Visual Communication entrance exams, and National Aptitude Test in Architecture. Students would also be guided in portfolio preparation.

Besides, children aged 10 and above and women can learn drawing and painting, and Indian folk arts.

The studio is located at A2, Seapoint Apartments, Number: 70, Beach Road, Kalakshetra Colony. Phone : 90032 70749.

Workshops on baking and cloth dyeing

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME -Tamil Nadu, is conducting a training programme on baking from April 15 to 17 at its premises on EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Ekkattuthangal. Another workshop on cloth dyeing will be held on April 16.

According to a press release, the programme will focus on sustainable and traditional dyeing practices. Time: From 10 to 5 p.m. Prior registration is required. For details, call 8668102600 / 87544 95254.

Panchangam 2026 release in Mandavelipakkam

The Tamil New Year day celebration will be conducted at Kalyana Nagar Association, T.M.S.Salai, Mandavelipakkam on April 14. The Association would be publishing the Panchangam for the year 2026.



Traditional handicrafts on sale in Alwarpet

An exhibition-cum-sale by Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Artisans Welfare Association has traditional handicrafts on display.

One can shop for bronze, brass statues, wood carving, stone and paintings. Also check out rosewood, wooden puja mandapam, decorative artifacts and gift articles.

The sale is on till April 26 at Srushti Handicrafts Emporium, Sudarshan Building, Chamiers Road, Alwarpet. Ph:044-42060730.

Telugu course from April 18

The World Telugu Federation is conducting a three month Telugu course from April 18 at its premises at Ankur Plaza, G.N. Chetty Road, T. Nagar. According to a press release, no fee will be charged. Phone: 7305557322



Akshaya Tritiya offer

Akshaya Tritiya, one of the most auspicious days to invest in gold, silver and precious jewellery, will be observed on April 19.

Lalithaa Jewellery is offering prices that are lower than competitive rates, ensuring customers receive more for every rupee that is being spent. As part of the festive offering, customers can get a one percent discount on the prevailing gold rate on all gold jewellery purchases, resulting in better value per gram, said a press release. For those looking to invest in diamonds, the jewellery mart is offering ₹ 4,000 per carat. The offer is valid from April 12 to 20, the release added. In addition, Lalithaa continues its commitment to transparent pricing by offering zero percent value addition on all gold coins, making them an ideal choice for both investment and gifting. Silver buyers can also benefit from no wastage and making charges on 90 percent of silverware, ensuring affordability without hidden costs. Further enhancing the offering are Lalithaa's flexible purchase and savings plans, designed to make jewellery buying more convenient and rewarding. Customers can benefit from 100 percent no-value-addition on jewellery purchase plans, along with pre-booking options that allow them to secure jewellery at favourable prices, stated the release.

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Plot in CIT Colony misused

RAMDAS NAIK

This TNHB plot in CIT Colony, Mylapore has been abandoned and misused. Despite repeated appeals to officials and elected representatives, no action has been forthcoming. The plot is being misused as a dumping ground for soil, mud and now rubbish. This space attracts stray dogs and is a major health hazard. CIT RWA requests the authorities to make this plot an extension of the park abutting it, which would be helpful for all the residents of the colony and users of the park.

Ramdas Naik is secretary CIT Colony RWA



Bins shrink road space at Mangollai



▼ The traffic in Mangollai is heavy with many vehicles coming to the area from Mathala Narayanan Street and North Mada Street. The road is already narrow and with these bins that have come up there, the motorable road space has shrunk further. *Text and photo by Baskar Seshari from Mylapore*

A ‘developing’ story with civic and social underpinnings



PRINCE FREDERICK

Designing community spaces falls into two loose taxonomies. The first one involves a space where nothing exists to thwart the purpose. Head in there and knuckle down to the work of turning it into a space for all, and not a fairyfly would buzz in protest. No better example than OSR land up for development of parks. There is a clear policy behind it, and everyone involved follows the letter of the law.

In the other taxonomy are roadside spaces. This is a coarse-grained category, one militating against standard action plans. Expect curveballs. Expect regression to a former state of chaos, after some progress in designing it has been made. On the upside, expect to see unlikely heroes emerge during the process of reclaiming the space. Belonging to this category with a fuzzy border is a space along East Mada Street in Thiruvanniyur, one sandwiched between the temple tank and the

A civic engagement of a kind that involves multiple stakeholders, Project Thiruvanniyur Mada Street is refreshing its initiative to reclaim a space from unauthorised parking and squalor

road. In mid-November of 2025, residents rallied behind Project Thiruvanniyur Mada Street, spearheaded by two architects, Dhanya Rajagopal and Pavithra Sriram and Design Co Lab, to reclaim this space from unauthorised parking and general squalor for art, culture, music, hyperlocal history, community, reading and for a plain hangout culture.

After the pilot, the effort got derailed to some extent with unauthorised parking rearing its head again, triggering a fresh wave of efforts to reclaim the space all over again. The life stories of the *dramatis personae* in this live theatre of civic responsibility are hugely varied. Enter a patron. “A patron came forward to pave a 480 sq.ft. of space in front of the Anna statue. The paving was completed in



▼ The community space at East Mada Street in Thiruvanniyur.



mid-January.” In Pavithra’s words, paving the space gave a sense of permanence and completeness to it. Enter a guardian. Pavithra notes that from mid-January to now, the space has been protected against misuse and vandalism with the help of a shopkeeper around the space. Owner of a briyani shop, Sabari cares for the space without a title; he monitors it and tips off the people powering the project about any issues.

Enter multiple contributors. Through crowd-funding, they have placed bin-based planters around the paved area to ward off the evil of unauthorised parking.

Enter creative collectives. One classic example is Pagir (@pagir-chennai41) which incidentally is organising a drive to beautify the drum planters at this space on April 12 (from 4 a.m. onwards).

The engagement of a multiplicity of constituencies with this com-

munity space has had a multiplier effect on it, making it vibrant and inclusive. To underline the multiple uses this space is being put to, Pavithra notes that during the Pangu festival, an annadhanam was conducted there; and for heritage walks that are part of the project, this space is the starting point; and a celebratory and decorative shelter was created for Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin’s birthday. On the plans for the immediate future, Pavithra points out that one has to do with having a space on North Mada Street, part of the corner it forms with East Mada Street, to be paved as well. Having a resource person who would gather data pertaining to people’s behaviour with respect to this community space that would drive expansion moves is also being considered. CSR funding opportunities are also being explored.

Pavithra points out the presence of a WhatsApp group that drives activities pertaining to development of this community space; to be part of this WhatsApp and to volunteer, one can call 9080892008. The project can be followed on Instagram (@projectthiruvanniyurmadastr).

Unsung Heroes Award presented to women from armed forces



At the award function.

The seventh edition of the Unsung Heroes Award, hosted by the Rotary Club of Madras East, honoured women from armed forces who have risen above personal loss and grief to serve society with strength, dignity, and purpose.

This year's awards, sponsored by the Congruent Foundation, recognised extraordinary individuals

whose service to society often goes unnoticed yet creates profound and lasting impact, said a release.

The awardees are: Metamorphes Foundation, represented by Veer Naari Shakunthala A. Bhandarkar, co-founder and director, wife of Late Col. Bhandarkar, a Shaurya Chakra awardee, whose work reflects resilience and unwavering

commitment to supporting fellow Veer Naris.

Veer Ratna Foundation (VRF), founded by Subhashini Venugopal, wife of Late Col. Venugopal, an Ashoka Chakra awardee, and represented by Archana Chakravarthy, CEO, continuing a mission dedicated to the welfare and empowerment of martyrs' families.



DIY activities at Kalaa Manjari

Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center in Alwarpet is conducting a half-day summer camp for children from April 13 to the end of May (between 10 a.m. and 1 p.m. every day)

The camp will feature a range of do-it-yourself and activity-based sessions, including craft, chess basics, origami, fireless cooking, clay modelling, art, games, yoga, sustainable craft, and puzzles.

The programme will be held at Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center, 25/13, 2nd Street, East Abhiramapuram, Alwarpet. For details, call 98402 25570 or 91766 10660.

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An initiative to empower residents of Royapuram

NVMM Institute of Job Skills invites interested individuals to explore a career in teaching

NVMM Institute of Job Skills, which has been running various programmes to empower youth in Royapuram, has added a new initiative to its list: teacher training.

Professor K.Narashiman, who re-

tired from Anna University; and N.Vijayee, who retired from Tamil Nadu Electricity Board are starting government-approved diploma courses in teacher training.

The one-year diploma course of Bharat Sevak Samaj, a Government

of India initiative, will help develop skill and enrich job opportunities. The programmes are centred around Montessori and Child Education. The courses will be a wonderful opportunity for youth and adults to build a career in teaching at a very low fees with flexi timings, said a release.

The two retired professional are residents of Kotturpuram and were brought up in North Chennai. Since 2022, they have been running programmes to develop the region through education especially among the youth.

For details, call 9444777661, 9444760489

Woman entrepreneur wins award

Dr. Anita Ramesh, an entrepreneur, was awarded for her contribution to 'Pradhan Mantri Bharathiya JanAushadhi Pariyojana'.

This is a campaign and public welfare scheme, launched by the Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers, Government of India, to expand its scope and strengthen its mission of providing quality generic medicines at affordable prices to the public.

The award was handed to Anitha Ramesh by J.P. Nadda, Union Minister for Chemicals and Fertilizers and Health, at a function in Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, in March.

A top woman entrepreneur in India for the Jan Aushadhi generic medicine, her work was ranked among the top-performing contributors in the country.

This achievement marks a significant milestone in her journey to improve access to essential medicines. Her efforts reflect a continued commitment to community welfare and inclusive healthcare, with a focus on delivering cost-effective solutions to a broader population.



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